One Hot Mess

By Carmen Agra Deedy

CARMEN: **(Pgs 43-61)** When you're a kid you think your family is normal. You assume ***everybody*** has a family that celebrates New Year's Day with a Jell-O fight on the lawn, or [a mom who] sets a fire in the bathtub on moving day . . . A little background on that last one.

My parents were Cuban refugees. We grew up in a small Southern town where they worked, paid taxes, and went to church. As far as I could tell, they were pretty ordinary people.

Okay, so maybe my mother liked to clean -- a lot. She descended from a long line of Iberian women who believed it their mission to rid the world of dirt and grime. In her defense, my mother's grandmother and sister both died of typhoid fever in 1930's Havana. This terrible loss marked the beginning of Mami's lifelong campaign against "The Godless Germ." As part of her arsenal, she kept a spray can of Lysol disinfectant tucked in her pocketbook.

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MAMI: *(spraying Lysol everywhere, speaks with a strong Cuban accent)* Danger never takes a holiday and ***nothing*** is more dangerous than The Godless Germ!

INTRODUCTION

It's true, every family is crazy in their own special way – and Carmen's Cuban-American family is chock full of wild and unforgettable traditions. But sometimes, even the weirdest family moments can bring us closer together -- For instance, has anyone in your family ever set a bathtub on fire?

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CARMEN: I never thought any of this odd, until the year I turned nine. It was our fourth move in five years. My dad, Papi, was a steel worker, and money was always tight. We would stay in a place until the rent went up, and then we'd pull up stakes and move into another house usually no more than two or three blocks and a decade older than the last one.

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But this time was different. Papi's willingness to work extra hours at the steel mill had earned him a raise, and our family the nicest place we had rented yet. No more crappy old clapboard houses with rusted faucets, warped windowsills, and bathrooms with chipped tiles. No sirree. We were moving into an apartment complex with a flower bed in the parking lot, and a swimming pool.

I remember how excited Marni was when we walked into apartment number eight. It was freshly painted and carpeted, and everything smelled of newness with a capital ***N***. Even our battered furniture looked a little brighter. When Papi arrived with hamburgers from the corner diner, I just knew this day couldn't possibly get any better.

PAPI: I'm going back to the house for the last load.

CARMEN: *(to Papi)* Wait for me! *(to audience)* I shoved the last bites of greasy burger into my mouth, pushed the chair away from the table, and headed after him. When I stepped outside, a

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shaggy-haired kid was bouncing an old tennis ball against the wall next to our apartment.

RONALD: *(bouncing the ball)* You moving into number eight?

CARMEN: *(to audience)* I beamed at him what I hoped was my most winning "you-bet-I-am-and-is-today-your-lucky-day-or-***WHAT***-because-you-get-dibs-on-the-new-kid" smile. *(to Ronald)* You wanna watch my mom set fire to the bathtub?

(to audience) He just stared at me with luminescent green eyes that reminded me of winter antifreeze. Then, in infinitesimal increments -- like molasses seeping from a broken jar along a cold winter floor, one millimeter at a time -- a smile spread across his face. It kept spreading, until it bunched up his cheeks and reached his eyes. Then, and only then, did he speak.

RONALD: Boy howdy, do I!

CARMEN: Great! Come on! She's almost ready. *(to audience)* He followed me into the apartment without hesitation. I watched him take in the

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neat rows of labeled boxes, the cheap Naugahyde recliner, the shiny Formica kitchen table. A perplexed look settled on his face.

RONALD: So, is your mama a pyro? 'Cause this don't look like no pyro's house; you still got plenty of stuff that'll burn.

CARMEN: What's a ***pie-rou****?*

RONALD: Somebody who lights stuff on fire so's they can watch it burn.

CARMEN: No! My mom doesn't like to watch the bathtub ***burn****.* She likes to watch the germs ***die****.*

RONALD: *(with a shocked look)* She . . . say ***what****?*

CARMEN: The look on his face made that hastily eaten burger stir treacherously in my stomach. Until that instant, I'd genuinely believed that ***everyone's*** mother did this. A hot, prickly sensation crept its way up my neck. I recognized it for what it was: shame. ***Burning a bathtub was weird.*** *(to Ronald, stammering)* L-l-let me explain.

RONALD: I cain't wait to hear.

CARMEN: *(to audience)* So I told him. I told him about my mother's dead grandmother and sister back in

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Cuba. I told him about the spray can of Lysol in her pocketbook. I told him the world was filled with all manner of invisible bugs just waiting to eat out your brains and turn your guts to mush and kill you deader than dead with just an innocent swipe of a doorknob. And when I finished telling, do you know what he did? *(beat)*

RONALD: *(laughing uproariously)*

CARMEN: He laughed. He laughed so hard he wheezed. He laughed so long he swallowed his gum and coughed it back up again. And do you know what I did? *(punches)* I punched him in the arm.

RONALD: *(stumbling sideways and laughing harder)*Easy, girl. *(more laughing)* You got a mean right hook there.

MAMI: What is going on here ...?

CARMEN: Mami stood in the doorway and looked from me to this alien child and back again. *(to Mami)* He's my friend. His name is. . . *(whispering to Ronald)* What's your name?

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RONALD: *(to Mami)* My name's Ronald, ma'am. Wayne Ronald Harding, but ever'body calls me Ronald.

CARMEN: My mother nodded, as if this was enough information for anybody.

MAMI: *(turning to Carmen)* I find the matches. The bathtub, she burn in ten minutes.

CARMEN: And I was relieved when she turned on her heel and disappeared down the short hall. *(to Ronald)* This is kinda crazy, huh?

RONALD: It's better'n crazy. This here's an ***opportunity***. *(leans in and whispers)* Let's sell tickets!

CARMEN: And that's what we did. Ronald rustled up a half dozen of his friends and told them that, for a quarter, they'd see something worth telling their grandchildren about someday. I stood in front of the door to number eight and explained what was about to happen to the small but eager crowd.

First, I said, my mom would scrub the bathtub with a bristle brush. Then she'd make certain there was nothing flammable in the room. As an

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added precaution, she'd place a bucket of water on the toilet. Next, she'd screw off the lid of a sixteen-ounce bottle of isopropyl alcohol and cover the tub's surface.

Then, and only then, would she strike the match and toss it in. I'd seen her do it time and again. It was a marvelous sight. Those old ceramic tubs would burst into flames, and just as quickly the fire would burn itself out.

RONALD: *(to the crowd of kids)* Now, I ask you, ain't that the dangdest thing y'all ever heard? So, who's in?

CARMEN: Kids tripped over one another to hand over their quarters. Mami was visibly startled when she saw me coming down the hall, a mob of children following along behind. *(pleading with Mami)* Can they watch, too?

MAMI: *(shakes her head)* Ay, ay, ay!

CARMEN: But then she put aside whatever misgivings she may have had; she had work to do. The Godless Germ waits for no woman, and we had to have baths that night.

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MAMI: *(to the crowd)* Okay, childrens. You no go in bathroom. You stay in door. NO GO IN. ***Me comprenden?***

CARMEN: Whether they understood or not, no one was leaving. No one was ***breathing***. This was a tale, as Ronald had promised, that they would tell their grandchildren.

My mother unscrewed the top of the bottle of alcohol. She moved the bucket of water closer to the tub. She upturned the bottle and drained the contents with great care. She reached into her apron pocket and drew from it a small box of wooden matches -- The crowd pressed forward.

MAMI: ***Tranquilos!***

CARMEN: Again, no one moved. But all eyes watched as she struck the match and tossed it in a perfect flaming arc into the bathtub. The brand-spanking-new ***FIBERGLASS*** bathtub. The thing lit up like kerosene-soaked kindling. The plastic melted and warped as the fire spread.

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Kids began to shriek as they scattered in a panic for the front door. Only three people held their ground: my mother, who flipped on the bathroom faucet and splashed bucket after bucket onto the flames; me, too terrified to run, or scream, or be of any use to anyone whatsoever; and Ronald. Well. . . Ronald actually disappeared briefly. He returned moments later, followed by a man in a ribbed white T-shirt who was carrying a fire extinguisher.

RONALD'S DAD: *(puts out the fire with the extinguisher)*

CARMEN: Within seconds the bathroom was a blanket of white foam, giving the room the look of a peaceful, if bizarre, Christmas postcard -- so long as you were unaware of the horror that lay beneath.

RONALD'S DAD: *(softly and unflustered)* Now, that is one hot mess, ma'am! *(beat)* I just gotta ask. What in the world made you want to light a tub on fire?

CARMEN: *(to Ronald's Dad)* She had to kill The Godless Germ!

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RONALD'S DAD: *(nodding and chuckling)* Well, I reckon that explains it about as well as anything.

CARMEN: None of the apartment kids were allowed to play with me after that day. Heck, they weren't even allowed to pass my door without an escort. Except for Ronald. He showed up the next morning.

RONALD: Hey!

CARMEN: I'm surprised your parents let you talk to me.

RONALD: Ain't got parents; got a dad. You met him. He's a firefighter, down Ladder 11 way. He said to call him if anything else catches fire!

CARMEN: *(embarrassed)* You're not funny! *(to audience)* My face felt as hot as melting fiberglass.

RONALD: You know, I had me an uncle once who swore up and down that for every lie I told, Santa Claus would have to eat one of his reindeer.

CARMEN: That's crazy . . .

RONALD: It's only crazy ***when somebody else's family does it.***

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CARMEN: And I knew then that Wayne Ronald Harding and I would be friends forever. *(beat)* Or at least until the rent went up again.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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